

A BEGINNER'S GUIDE

دليل الترجمة

مرشد للمبتدئين في الترجمة بين العربية والإنجليزية

Translation Handbook

A beginner's guide to translating between English and Arabic



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First edition, 2026

Translation Handbook: A Beginner's Guide to Translating between English and Arabic

First edition, 2026. Prepared by the Translation Team, Guild Professional Club, for use in the Guild Season workshops.

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Quotations from published works are used for teaching purposes and are fully acknowledged in the References. Unless another source is given, examples come from the Translation Team's course materials or were written for this handbook.

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Preface

This handbook was prepared by the Translation Team of the Guild Professional Club for students who are taking their first steps in translation between English and Arabic. It will be used in the team's workshops during the Guild Season, and it is written so that it can also be read on its own.

The handbook brings together the team's course materials, organises them into a clear order, and adds the chapters, examples and exercises that a beginner needs. Its aims are simple. By the end of it, you should:

- know the basic rules and principles of translation;
- understand the main **differences** between English and Arabic;
- recognise the main **difficulties** that translators meet;
- be able to use practical **strategies and techniques** to solve them;
- be able to check your own work and explain your choices.

We hope that this handbook opens the way for you, and that it is the first of many steps.

The Translation Team

Acknowledgements

The Translation Team thanks every team member who collected material, examples and practice texts for this handbook.

How to use this handbook

From easy to hard

The handbook moves step by step, from the simplest ideas to the more demanding ones. Each part builds on the one before it, so read it in order:

1. **Part 1: Getting started.** What translation is, how to prepare, and how English and Arabic differ.
2. **Part 2: Understanding meaning.** Form and meaning, types of meaning, and context.
3. **Part 3: Words that go together.** Collocations, idioms and proverbs.
4. **Part 4: Methods and techniques.** Equivalence, literal and free translation, metaphors, the seven procedures and the main strategies.
5. **Part 5: Culture and new words.** Cultural approximation, descriptive translation and lexical creation.
6. **Part 6: Working with whole texts.** Text analysis, text types, and words that show a point of view.
7. **Part 7: Tools and resources.** Dictionaries, terminology management, and machine translation and AI.
8. **Part 8: Checking and explaining.** Revision and common mistakes, risk assessment, and translation commentary.
9. **Part 9: Audiovisual translation.** Types, theories and challenges of AVT, and subtitling.

At the end of the book you will find practice texts with answers, checklists, a glossary of all key terms, and the references.

How each chapter works

Every chapter follows the same simple pattern:

1. **Introduction:** what the chapter is about, and how it links to the previous one.
2. **Key terms:** the new words, each with its Arabic equivalent and a short definition. All key terms are also listed in the glossary.
3. **Explanation and examples:** short sections with examples in both languages.
4. **Try it:** a few questions to check your understanding, with the answers straight after.
5. **Remember:** the most important points of the chapter.

Signs used in this handbook

- **EN → AR**: translating from English into Arabic. **AR → EN**: translating from Arabic into English.
- ✓ marks a good translation and ✗ a poor one.
- Words in **bold** are key terms.

Sources

The ideas in this handbook come from the Translation Team's course materials and from published works on translation. Published sources are cited in the text, for example (Newmark, 1988), and listed in full in the References. Unless another source is given, the examples come from the team's course materials (Translation Team, n.d.) or were written for this handbook.

Abbreviations

- **AI:** artificial intelligence (الذكاء الاصطناعي)
- **AR → EN:** from Arabic into English
- **EN → AR:** from English into Arabic
- **MSA:** Modern Standard Arabic (الفصحى المعاصرة)
- **MT:** machine translation (الترجمة الآلية)
- **SL:** source language (اللغة المصدر); **SLC:** source language culture
- **ST:** source text (النص المصدر)
- **TL:** target language (اللغة الهدف); **TLC:** target language culture
- **TS:** Translation Studies (دراسات الترجمة)
- **TT:** target text (النص الهدف)

Part 1: Getting started

Part 1 is for readers who are completely new to translation. It explains what translation is, gives you practical advice for preparing a translation, and shows the main differences between English and Arabic.

Chapter 1: Translation and the translator

In this chapter. This first chapter answers three basic questions: What is translation? What kinds of translation are there? And what does a good translator need?

KEY TERMS

- **Translation** (الترجمة التحريرية): Transferring the meaning of a written text from one language into another.
- **Interpreting** (الترجمة الشفهية): Transferring spoken language into another language.
- **Source text (ST)** (النص المصدر): The original text that you translate.
- **Target text (TT)** (النص الهدف): Your translation.
- **Approximation** (التقريب): Bringing the meaning of the source text as close as possible to the target language.
- **Commissioned translator** (مترجم بتكليف): A translator who works for a client.
- **Self-initiated translator** (مترجم بمبادرة ذاتية): A translator who chooses a text to translate, with no client.

What is translation?

Imagine a friend who only speaks Arabic asks you what an English sign says. You would not read the English words out one by one. You would tell your friend what the sign **means**, in good Arabic. That is translation.

The team's course materials define translation as "an activity or process of transferring textual meaning from one language to another" (Translation Team, n.d.). Peter Newmark describes it in a similar way: "rendering the meaning of a text into another language in the way that the author intended the text" (Newmark, 1988, p. 5).

So a translator carries **meaning**, not words. English speakers say *Break a leg!* to wish someone good luck:

Word by word: اكسر ساقاً ✗ By meaning: بالتوفيق ✓

Translation is approximation

No two languages match perfectly, so a translation can never be an exact copy.

Translation is therefore a process of **approximation**: the translator brings the meaning as

close as possible to the target language, especially its cultural meaning (Chapter 14). The writer Umberto Eco gave his book on translation the title *Dire quasi la stessa cosa*, “saying almost the same thing” (Eco, 2003).

Translation is communication

Communication means to understand and to be understood. Translation is communication between two languages: you first receive the message in one language, then pass it on in the other. If your reader does not understand it, the translation has not worked.

Types of translation

- **Written translation:** translating written texts. This handbook is about written translation.
- **Interpreting:** translating speech, either while the speaker is talking (simultaneous) or after the speaker stops (consecutive).
- **Sight translation:** reading a written text aloud in another language.
- **Audiovisual translation**, such as subtitling and dubbing: translating films, television and video games within limits of time and space (Part 9).
- **Localisation:** adapting a product, such as a website or an app, to the language and culture of another country.

Methods such as literal and free translation are explained in Chapter 10.

What does a good translator need?

The course materials name two main characteristics: the translator should have **bilingual knowledge**, and **cultural knowledge** that is equal to that linguistic knowledge. In addition, a good translator:

- is fluent in both the source language and the target language;
- is **bicultural** (مُلمّ بالثقافتين): knows both cultures well;
- has wide general knowledge, like a “walking encyclopedia”, and learns about the topic of each text;
- has a rich **linguistic repertoire** (الحصيلة اللغوية), including idioms and fixed expressions;
- gains experience through practice and revision.

More than a thousand years ago, the Arab writer al-Jāḥiẓ said the same: a translator must know both languages equally well (al-Jāḥiẓ, 1965):

ولا بدّ للترجمان من أن يكونَ بياؤه في نفس الترجمة في وزنِ علمه في نفس المعرفة،
وينبغي أن يكونَ أعلم الناس باللغة المنقولة والمنقول إليها، حتى يكونَ فيهما سواءٌ
وغاية.

Two kinds of translator

A **commissioned translator** works for a client, who asks for the translation. Clients often have their own style, ideology and policy, and the translator must follow them (Chapter 19). A freelancer, who works for different clients, is a commissioned translator. A **self-initiated translator** has no client: you choose your own text, such as a poem you love, and you make all the decisions.

Try it

1. What is the difference between translation and interpreting?
2. Is a freelancer a commissioned or a self-initiated translator?
3. Why is translation called “approximation”?

Answers

1. Translation deals with written texts; interpreting deals with speech.
2. Commissioned: a freelancer works for clients.
3. Because no two languages match perfectly, so the translator brings the meaning as close as possible to the target language.

REMEMBER

- Translation carries **meaning** from one language to another, not words.
- A good translator needs two languages **and** two cultures.
- Commissioned translators follow their client's policy; self-initiated translators choose their own texts.

Chapter 2: Tips, advice and preparation

In this chapter. Now that you know what translation is, you need to know how to begin. This chapter gives you the questions to ask before you start, the steps to prepare a text, and the habits of good translators. It ends with a complete example that takes one sentence through the whole process.

KEY TERMS

- **Client** (العميل): The person or organisation that asks for a translation.
- **Communicative purpose** (الغرض التواصلي): What the translation is for: to inform, persuade, instruct or entertain.
- **Target audience** (الجمهور المستهدف): The people who will read the translation.
- **Translation brief** (موجز الترجمة): The information you need before you start: client, purpose and audience.
- **Mental draft** (المسودة الذهنية): A first idea of the translation that you form while reading the text.

Ask three questions

The same text can be translated in different ways. A news report for experts and a leaflet for children need different words. Christiane Nord explains that the purpose of a translation decides how it should be translated (Nord, 1997). So before you start, ask:

1. **Who is the client?** (من هو العميل؟) Clients have their own style and rules.
2. **What is the communicative purpose?** (ما الغرض التواصلي؟) To inform, to persuade, to instruct or to entertain?
3. **Who is the target audience?** (من هو الجمهور المستهدف؟) Experts or the general public? Adults or children?

The answers are your **translation brief**. If nobody gives you a brief, ask the client. If you chose the text yourself, answer the questions yourself.

For example, you are asked to translate a short news report for KUNA, the Kuwait News Agency. The purpose is to inform English readers who are interested in Kuwait. So your translation should be formal and neutral, with a short headline.

Prepare in five steps

1. **Read the whole text** once, just to understand it. With every new reading, new ideas appear.
2. **Read it again with a pen.** Highlight difficult words, idioms, names and numbers.
3. **Research** the topic if you do not know it well.

4. **List the key terms** and check them (Chapters 20 and 21).
5. **Form a mental draft:** picture how the translation should sound, and decide whether you are ready or need more resources.

Work from the whole to the parts

A long text can feel difficult. Break it down: divide each paragraph into sentences, each sentence into phrases, and each phrase into words. Work out the meaning of each part, then rebuild it in the target language. Watch the links between sentences, such as cause and effect, and keep them in your translation.

Tips from experienced translators

- **Be faithful** (الأمانة): do not add or remove meaning. Aim for a translation that is faithful, accurate and acceptable to the reader.
- **Remember that translation is rewriting:** the result must read naturally, as if it had been written in the target language.
- **Tread carefully:** translation is like a minefield (الترجمة كحقل ألغام). Know what is appropriate in both languages and cultures.
- **Prose is stricter than poetry:** in poetry you have more freedom to be creative.
- **Keep titles short,** and do not add information to titles and headlines.
- **Translate everything,** including captions and notes.
- **Always revise,** even your best translation (Chapter 23).
- **Keep it simple.** Simplicity is key.
- **Protect your reputation:** quality and speed together make you productive.

Putting it together: your first translation

Here is the whole process on one short sentence. Each step is explained later in the handbook.

It's raining cats and dogs, so the match has been cancelled.

1. **Prepare** (this chapter). A school wants to tell Arabic-speaking parents about the match. The purpose is to inform, so the Arabic should be clear and simple.
2. **Understand** (Chapters 4 to 8). *Raining cats and dogs* is an idiom. It has nothing to do with animals: it means "raining heavily".

3. **Translate** (Chapters 9 to 16). A word-by-word version, إنها تمطر قططاً وكلاباً، لذلك تمّ إلغاء المباراة أُلغيت المباراة بسبب الأمطار الغزيرة, makes no sense. A translation of the meaning works: أُلغيت المباراة بسبب الأمطار الغزيرة.
4. **Check** (Chapters 23 and 24). Read the Arabic without the English: the meaning is complete, and the sentence sounds natural.
5. **Explain** (Chapter 25). “The idiom was translated by its meaning, because a word-for-word version would make no sense to Arab readers.”

Try it

1. A hospital asks you to translate a medicine leaflet for its patients. Who is the target audience, and what style should you use?
2. What is the purpose of an advert?
3. Why should you read the whole text before you start translating?

Answers

1. Patients from the general public, so the style must be clear and simple, with exact words.
2. To persuade.
3. To understand it, find the difficult parts in advance, and form a mental draft.

REMEMBER

- Ask three questions first: **client, purpose, audience**.
- Read the whole text at least twice before you translate.
- Be faithful, write naturally, and always revise.

Chapter 3: English and Arabic: key differences

In this chapter. Every language has its own habits. This chapter shows the main differences between English and Arabic, so that you can avoid the most common problems from your very first translation. The advice here is based on the course materials and on Farghal and Shunnaq (1999) and Ghazala (2008).

KEY TERMS

- **Word order** (ترتيب الكلمات): The order of the subject, verb and object in a sentence.
- **Verbal sentence** (الجملة الفعلية): A sentence that starts with a verb.
- **Register** (المستوى اللغوي): How formal or informal the language is.
- **Modern Standard Arabic (MSA)** (الفصحى المعاصرة): The Arabic of newspapers, laws and education.
- **Dialect** (اللهجة العامية): The everyday spoken Arabic of a country or region.

Word order: start with the verb

English usually puts the subject first (Subject-Verb-Object). Arabic usually starts with the verb (Verb-Subject-Object). One of the first rules of translating into Arabic is therefore to start with the verb:

Sam ate the cake. → أكل سامُ الكعكة ✗ ✓ سام أكل الكعكة

The government announced new measures. → أعلنت الحكومة إجراءاتٍ جديدة

Sentence length and linking

English prefers short sentences with full stops. Arabic often joins several ideas in one long sentence with *و*, *ف* and *ثمّ*. When you translate into Arabic, join short sentences; when you translate into English, split long ones. Linking words help your Arabic flow: *غير أنّ* (however), *لذلك* (therefore), *بالإضافة إلى ذلك* (in addition), *على سبيل المثال* (for example).

Synonyms

Arabic often places two synonyms side by side for emphasis; English rarely does. So *شجاعٌ ومُغوارٌ* becomes *very brave*, not *brave and daring*.

The verb “to be”

English always writes *is* and *are*; Arabic often leaves them out. When *is* is the main verb of an English sentence, Arabic can use *يُعدّ* or *تُعدّ*: *Translation is a fascinating field* → تُعدّ الترجمة مجالاً شائقاً. In the other direction, add the verb: *The student is in the library* → الطالب في المكتبة.

Gender and numbers

- English *you* is أَنْتَ (a man) or أَنْتِ (a woman). As Roman Jakobson observed, “languages differ essentially in what they must convey and not in what they may convey” (Jakobson, 1959, p. 236).
- With the numbers 3 to 10, the number takes the opposite gender to the noun: ثلاثة طلاب but ثلاث طالبات.
- Some feminine job titles also have another meaning (نائبة can mean “calamity”; قاضية can mean “fatal”), so some writers avoid them. Today, however, قاضية and نائبة are widely used for women judges and members of parliament.

Small words, big traps

Some short English words look easy but must not be translated with their first dictionary meaning:

- *He is in bed.* → إنه نائم (not في السرير)
- *As an officer, I...* → بصفتي ضابطاً; *As the manager of the company...* → بصفتي مديراً الشركة (here *as* means a role, not ك)
- *Shops stay open.* → تظل المحلات التجارية مفتوحة
- *Eventually* → في نهاية المطاف
- *...to see the Roman ruins* → لزيارة الآثار الرومانية (Arabic prefers “visit”)

Punctuation

Use Arabic punctuation in Arabic texts: the Arabic comma , , semicolon ؛ and question mark ؟.

Which Arabic?

- **Classical Arabic** (العربية الفصحى التراثية): the Arabic of the Qur'an and classical poetry.
- **Modern Standard Arabic**: the Arabic of newspapers, laws and education. Use it for written translation.
- **Dialects** (اللهجات العامية): everyday spoken Arabic. Use a dialect only if the client asks for it, for example in film subtitles.

Four common challenges

Most problems in English–Arabic translation fall into four groups: **grammar** (النحو), **word choice** (الدلالة), **punctuation and style**, and **general or technical texts**. Style includes knowing when to be formal and when to use dialect.

Try it

1. Rewrite in natural Arabic: الطلاب حضروا المحاضرة.
2. Translate: الطالب في المكتبة.
3. Translate: *He is in bed.*

Answers

1. حضر الطلابُ المحاضرةَ.
2. *The student is in the library.*
3. إنه نائمٌ.

REMEMBER

- **EN → AR:** start with the verb, join short sentences, use Arabic punctuation.
- **AR → EN:** start with the subject, split long sentences, keep one of two synonyms, add “is”.
- Use Modern Standard Arabic unless the client asks for a dialect.

Part 2: Understanding meaning

You cannot translate what you do not understand. Part 2 explains how meaning works: why meaning is more important than form, the different kinds of meaning, and how context tells you which meaning is right.

Chapter 4: Form and meaning

In this chapter. In Chapter 3 you saw that English and Arabic build sentences differently. This chapter explains the rule that allows you to change the structure of a sentence safely: meaning comes before form.

KEY TERMS

- **Form** (البناء): The structure of language: a word, phrase, clause, sentence or text.
- **Meaning** (المعنى): The idea that a form expresses.

The golden rule

Behind every form there is a meaning. In translation we favour meaning over form (المعنى): (أهم من البناء) you may change the form, but you must never change the meaning. Meaning is the heart of translation. It is also complex, because it is cognitive: it exists in the mind, not on the page.

Nida and Taber (1969) make the same point: anything said in one language can be said in another. The only exception is when the form itself is part of the message, as in a poem's rhyme.

Changing the form

Forms differ from language to language, so it is acceptable to change the form. An adjective can become a verb, a noun can become a verb, and so on.

- *He is a heavy smoker.* → يدخن بشراهة (the adjective *heavy* becomes a verb phrase)
- *after his arrival* → بعد أن وصل (the noun *arrival* becomes a verb; see Chapter 12)

When the image does not travel

The British press described Tony Blair as *Bush's poodle*, meaning someone who obediently follows George Bush. The image of a poodle has no such meaning in Arabic, so the translator keeps the meaning and changes the form: بلير، المنقاد لبوش or بلير، تابع بوش.

Try it

1. Translate by changing the form: *He is a fast runner.*
2. Translate by changing the form: *His arrival was late.*

Answers

1. يركض بسرعة.
2. وصل متأخراً.

REMEMBER

- Meaning comes before form.
- You may change the structure, but never the meaning.

Chapter 5: Types of meaning

In this chapter. Chapter 4 showed that meaning is what you must keep. But meaning has layers. This chapter explains the basic meaning of a word, the feelings it carries, and the difference between what a sentence says and what a speaker means.

KEY TERMS

- **Denotation** (المعنى المعجمي): The basic, dictionary meaning of a word.
- **Connotation** (المعنى الإيحائي): The extra feeling or association a word carries.
- **Sentence meaning** (معنى الجملة): What the words of a sentence say.
- **Speaker meaning** (مقصد المتكلم): What the speaker really means by saying it.

Denotation and connotation

Words can share the same **denotation** but carry a different **connotation** (Baker, 2018). A good translator chooses the word with the right feeling as well as the right meaning:

- *die* (مات) is neutral; *pass away* (توفي) is polite and respectful; *kick the bucket* is informal and humorous.
- *steed* (جواد) suggests a fine, noble horse; *horse* (حصان) is neutral.
- *friend* (صديق) is general; *comrade* (رفيق) suggests a member of the same party or cause.
- *kill* (قتل) is general; *assassinate* (اغتيال) means killing for political reasons.

Sentence meaning and speaker meaning

Sometimes a speaker means more than the words say. The sentence *أشعرُ بالحرِّ* states a fact, but the speaker may mean “Please turn on the air conditioning”. *أصبح الجوُّ بارداً* may mean “Please turn it off”, and *It’s freezing in here* may mean “Please close the window”. Translate what the speaker means, in a way that sounds natural in the target language.

Try it

1. In an obituary, which is better: مات or توفي?
2. What might a guest mean by saying *It’s rather warm in here*?

Answers

1. توفي, because it is respectful.
2. A polite request to open a window or turn on the air conditioning.

REMEMBER

- Check the **connotation** of a word, not only its dictionary meaning.
- Translate what the speaker means, not only what the sentence says.

Chapter 6: Context

In this chapter. Chapters 4 and 5 showed that words carry different meanings and feelings. How do you know which one is right? The answer is context. This chapter explains what context is and how it helps you choose.

KEY TERMS

- **Context** (السياق): Any background information that helps us understand a text.
- **Micro context (co-text)** (السياق الداخلي): The words and sentences immediately around a word.
- **Macro context** (السياق الخارجي): The wider situation: the author, audience, time, place and circumstances of a text.
- **Homonymy** (المشترك اللفظي): One word with several meanings that are not related.
- **Polysemy** (تعدد المعنى): One word with several meanings that are related.

Every situation has its own words

In translation, always pay attention to context. As the Arabic saying goes, لكلِّ مقامٍ مقال: every situation has its own way of speaking.

Micro context and macro context

- **Micro context** is inside the text: the words and sentences around a word. It is sometimes called the co-text.
- **Macro context** is outside the text: the author (for example Nizar Qabbani or Mahmoud Darwish), the audience, the time and place of writing, and the social and historical background.

Picture a triangle. The **author** and the **audience** are at two corners, and the **text** passes between them. The **translator** stands in the middle and must know both sides.

One word, several meanings

When a word has several meanings, context tells you which one is right. If the meanings are unrelated, this is called **homonymy**; if they are related, it is **polysemy**.

- *bank*: مصرف (for money) or ضفة النهر (of a river). The meanings are unrelated.
- *case*: حالة (a situation), قضية (an issue or a court case) or علبة (a container, such as a phone case).
- *عين*: an eye, a water spring or a spy.
- *تطهير*: cleaning a wound (تطهير الجرح) or purifying from sins (تطهير الذنوب). The meanings are related.

- احتجاز: holding water (احتجاز المياه) or holding hostages (احتجاز الرهائن).

Try it

1. Translate *case* in: *The doctor examined the case.*
2. Translate شربنا من عين ماء باردة in: عين.

Answers

1. حالة.
2. *We drank from a cold water spring.*

REMEMBER

- Context decides which meaning is correct.
- Look at the words around a word (micro context) and at the whole situation (macro context).

Part 3: Words that go together

Some words cannot be translated one at a time, because they belong together. Part 3 explains collocations, idioms and proverbs, and shows how to translate them naturally.

Chapter 7: Collocation

In this chapter. In Part 2 you worked with the meaning of single words. Now you will see that words also have partners. This chapter explains collocations, the word partners of each language.

KEY TERMS

- **Collocation** (التلازم اللفظي): Words that naturally go together; the company a word keeps.

The company a word keeps

The course materials define collocation as “the company a word keeps”. This idea comes from the linguist J. R. Firth: “You shall know a word by the company it keeps” (Firth, 1957, p. 11). Each language has its own partners, so a collocation cannot be translated word by word (Baker, 2018).

Look at the English verb *pay*. Its basic meaning is to give money, but its partners change its meaning:

- *pay money* → يدفع المال (the basic meaning)
- *pay attention* → يُدفع الانتباه or أعرنى انتباهك (not يدفع الانتباه)
- *pay respect* → يُبدي احتراماً
- *pay a visit* → يدفع زيارة (not يقوم بزيارة)

More collocations

EN → AR

- *close cooperation* → تعاون وثيق; *a close friend* → صديق مقرب
- *strong tea* → شاي ثقيل (not شاي قوي)
- *a fast colour* → لون ثابت; *a fast friend* → صديق وفّي
- *break the law* → يخالف القانون (more natural than يكسر القانون)

AR → EN

- استل سيفه → *he drew his sword*
- يساورني القلق → *I am growing worried*
- قدّم استقالته → *he resigned*
- اتخذ قراراً → *he made a decision*
- عقد اجتماعاً → *he held a meeting*

Try it

1. Translate: *heavy rain*
2. Translate: *a close friend*
3. Translate: اتخذ قراراً

Answers

1. (مطر ثقيل not) مطر غزير.
2. صديق مقرب.
3. *He made a decision.*

REMEMBER

- Learn words **with their partners**.
- Translate a collocation with the natural partner in the other language.

Chapter 8: Idioms, proverbs and fixed expressions

In this chapter. Chapter 7 showed that some words go together. Idioms go one step further: their words are fixed, and together they mean something new. This chapter shows how to recognise and translate idioms and proverbs.

KEY TERMS

- **Idiom** (التعبير الاصطلاحي): A fixed expression of more than one word whose meaning is not the sum of the meanings of its words.
- **Proverb** (المثل): A traditional saying that gives advice or states a truth.

What is an idiom?

An **idiom** is a fixed group of words with a meaning of its own: *It's a piece of cake* means “it is easy”. The rule is simple: an idiom cannot be translated word by word. Translate its meaning, or use a target-language idiom with the same meaning (Baker, 2018).

Check the context first

The same words can sometimes be meant literally. *A piece of cake* usually means “easy” (سهل جداً), but at a birthday party it may simply mean قطعة من الكعك. Again: every communicative situation has its own context (لكلّ مقام مقال).

English idioms (EN → AR)

- *It's raining cats and dogs.* → تمطر بغزارة
- *to pull one's socks up* → شمر عن ساعديه
- *over the moon* → في قمة السعادة
- *to spill the beans* → أفشى السرّ
- *I'm all ears.* → كليّ آذان صاغية
- *Break a leg!* → بالتوفيق!
- *Mark my words.* → تذكّر كلامي
- *to hit the sack* → أوى إلى فراشه
- *Don't put words in my mouth.* → لا تتقول عليّ

Proverbs

For a proverb, look for a proverb with the same meaning in the other language. If there is none, give the meaning in plain words:

- *out of the frying pan into the fire* → كالمستجير من الرمضاء بالنار

- رجع بخُفِّي حُنين → *he came back empty-handed*
- عصفورٌ في اليد خيرٌ من عشرةٍ على الشجرة → *a bird in the hand is worth two in the bush*
- Boys will be boys. → الولد ولد ولو صار قاضي بلد
- Business is business. → العمل عمل

Try it

1. Translate: *It's a piece of cake.* (about an exam)
2. Translate: *to spill the beans*
3. Translate: رجع بخُفِّي حُنين.

Answers

1. الامتحان سهل جداً.
2. أفشى السرّ.
3. *He came back empty-handed.*

REMEMBER

- Never translate an idiom word by word.
- First check that the expression really is an idiom in this context.
- For proverbs, look for an equivalent proverb; if there is none, give the meaning.

Part 4: Methods and techniques

You now understand how meaning works and how words combine. Part 4 gives you the main methods and techniques for translating: equivalence, literal and free translation, metaphors, the seven translation procedures and the main translation strategies.

Chapter 9: Equivalence

In this chapter. Equivalence is one of the central ideas in Translation Studies. Translation has been defined as a process that seeks to establish equivalence between two languages at different levels. This chapter explains the three types of equivalence described by Farghal and Shunnaq (1999).

KEY TERMS

- **Equivalence** (التكافؤ): A match between a source-language expression and a target-language expression.
- **Formal equivalence** (التكافؤ الشكلي): Keeping the form of the original: passive for passive, verb for verb.
- **Functional equivalence** (التكافؤ الوظيفي): Using a target-language expression that serves the same function, whatever its form.
- **Ideational equivalence** (التكافؤ الفكري): Giving only the basic idea, in plain words.

Three types of equivalence

Formal equivalence respects the structure: passive to passive, verb to verb, adjective to adjective. **Functional equivalence** captures the function of the source expression without its form, using an expression that does the same job. **Ideational equivalence** conveys only the basic meaning.

One sentence, three choices

The agreement has remained a dead letter since then. A “dead letter” is an agreement that exists on paper but is never applied.

- **Formal:** وقد بقيت الاتفاقية حرفاً ميتاً منذ ذلك الوقت. The words are correct, but Arab readers will not understand the image.
- **Functional:** بقيت الاتفاقية حبراً على ورق منذ ذلك الوقت. A familiar Arabic idiom: the best choice here.
- **Ideational:** لم تُطبَّق الاتفاقية منذ ذلك الوقت. Clear, but the colour of the idiom is lost.

Note: *agreement* is اتفاقية and *treaty* is معاهدة. Keep the difference.

More examples

- *You should think outside the box.* Formal: فُكِّرْ خارج الصندوق (now used in Arabic too). Functional: فُكِّرْ بطريقة إبداعية.
- *Ali is second to none in writing poetry.* Functional: عليٌّ لا يُشَقُّ له غبار في كتابة الشعر. Ideational: عليٌّ متميِّز في كتابة الشعر.

Try formal equivalence first. If it does not work, look for a functional equivalent. If there is none, give the idea. Nida and Taber sum up the goal: “the closest natural equivalent of the source-language message, first in terms of meaning and secondly in terms of style” (Nida & Taber, 1969, p. 12).

Try it

1. Which type? *Ali is second to none in writing poetry.* → عليٌّ متميِّز في كتابة الشعر
2. Give a functional equivalent: *The agreement remained a dead letter.*

Answers

1. Ideational: only the basic idea is kept.
2. بقيت الاتفاقية حبراً على ورق.

REMEMBER

- There are three types of equivalence: formal, functional and ideational.
- Choose the one that gives the closest natural meaning for your reader.

Chapter 10: Literal and free translation

In this chapter. Chapter 9 showed three levels of closeness. This chapter looks at the two ends of that line. Literal translation stays close to the words; free translation stays close to the message.

KEY TERMS

- **Literal translation** (الترجمة الحرفية): Keeping the words of the original and changing only what the grammar requires. Also called modified literal translation (الترجمة الحرفية المعدلة).
- **Free translation** (الترجمة الحرة): Keeping the message but not the form; also called loose translation.
- **Adaptation** (الترجمة المكيّفة): A very free rewriting, which some specialists regard as a new text rather than a translation.

Literal translation: successful or destructive

Literal translation can be either successful or destructive (قد تكون الترجمة الحرفية ناجحة (أو مدمرة)). It is successful when the target language has the same expression, and destructive when it does not:

- *to play a role* → يلعب دوراً ✓
- *to pay a visit* → يدفع زيارة ✗ (يقوم بزيارة)
- *It has been a long day.* → لقد كان يوماً شاقاً ✗ (لقد كان يوماً طويلاً ✗)
- *What are you wearing on your biggest day?* → ماذا سترتدي في أهم يوم لديك؟ ✗ (ماذا سترتدي في يوم زفافك؟)

Free translation

Free translation gives the translator ample freedom, and it is used for all kinds of texts, not only literary works. But the freer the translation, the greater the risk of adding meaning that is not in the source. Compare these examples from the course materials:

- *Appointing new employees should be done on the basis of equal opportunity.* → تعيين الموظفين الجدد يجب أن يتم بعيداً عن المحسوبية والواسطة والمحاباة. A free translation that keeps the message.
- *Going out can be risky these days.* → a translator who knows the context (for example, the Covid-19 pandemic) might write a sentence about the virus spreading.
- *We have had heavy rainfall this winter.* → سيكون لدينا موسم زراعي مبشّر بالخير هذا العام.

- *His parents are not quite happy about what he said to them.* → a sentence about respecting one's parents.

The last three are very free: they add an interpretation or a new idea. Some specialists do not consider such adapted translations to be translations at all, but new texts. As a beginner, keep the message and do not add ideas.

Words or meaning?

Translators have asked this question for centuries. St Jerome, who translated the Bible into Latin, chose “not word for word but sense for sense” (Jerome, 395/2012). So did the great Abbasid translator Ḥunayn ibn Isḥāq (Baker & Hanna, 2009). As a beginner, follow the same advice: translate the meaning, but do not add ideas.

Try it

1. Is this literal translation successful? *to play a role* → يلعب دوراً
2. Correct: *It has been a long day.* → لقد كان يوماً طويلاً

Answers

1. Yes: Arabic uses the same expression.
2. لقد كان يوماً شاقاً.

REMEMBER

- Literal translation works only when the target language has the same expression.
- Free translation may change the form, but it should not add new ideas.

Chapter 11: Metaphoric translation

In this chapter. Chapters 9 and 10 dealt with ordinary language. Many texts, however, use figurative language. This chapter explains metaphors and similes and gives you steps for translating them.

KEY TERMS

- **Figurative language** (اللغة المجازية): Language used in a non-literal way to create an image or effect.
- **Metaphor** (الاستعارة): A comparison without “as” or “like”; using a word in a non-basic meaning.
- **Simile** (التشبيه): A comparison that uses “as” or “like”.

Metaphor and simile

A **metaphor** compares two things without *as* or *like*: *She is a moon*. A **simile** uses *as* or *like*: *She is as beautiful as the moon*. In Arabic terms, a metaphor uses a word in a non-literal way (استخدام اللفظ استخداماً غير حرفي). Poetry is especially rich in metaphors, because its language is very expressive.

Four steps for translating a metaphor

Follow these steps in order. They agree with the procedures described by Newmark (1988):

1. **If the metaphor is shared** by both languages, translate it literally. *She is a snake*. → إنها أفعى. *My thoughts evaporated*. → تبخّرت أفكاري. *My paper will see the light next December*. → سترى ورقتي البحثية النور في ديسمبر القادم.
2. **If it is not shared**, replace it with a target-language image with the same meaning. *This is the tip of the iceberg*. → هذا غيضٌ من فيض (in negative situations) or أول الغيث قطرة (in positive ones).
3. **Or turn it into a simile**: *He is a rock*. → إنه كالصخرة في ثباته.
4. **If nothing works**, give the basic meaning. This is the last choice, because the image is lost. *She is a snake* (if the image were not shared) → إنها خبيثة; *The news raised a few eyebrows*. → أثار الخبر دهشة بعضهم.

Try it

1. Translate: *My thoughts evaporated*.
2. Translate: *This is only the tip of the iceberg*. (about a scandal)

Answers

1. تَبَخَّرْتُ أَفْكَارِي.
2. هَذَا غَيْضٌ مِنْ فَيْضٍ.

REMEMBER

- Keep a shared image; replace an unshared one; turn it into a simile; give the plain meaning as a last choice.

Chapter 12: The seven translation procedures

In this chapter. Chapters 9 to 11 gave you general methods. This chapter gives you seven precise techniques, called translation procedures, described by Vinay and Darbelnet (1958/1995). Newmark explains the difference: “while translation methods relate to whole texts, translation procedures are used for sentences and the smaller units of language” (Newmark, 1988, p. 81).

KEY TERMS

- **Translation procedure** (إجراء الترجمة): A technique for translating a word, phrase or sentence.
- **Borrowing** (الاقتراض): Taking a word from the source language as it is.
- **Calque** (النسخ): Translating each part of an expression literally.
- **Transposition** (الإبدال): Changing the word class, for example a noun into a verb.
- **Modulation** (التحويل): Expressing the same idea from another point of view.
- **Adaptation (procedure)** (التكييف): Replacing a cultural situation with a familiar one.

The seven procedures

The first three are **direct** procedures: they stay close to the original. The last four are **oblique** procedures: they move further away. Try them in order, and move down the list only when the result sounds wrong.

1. **Borrowing** (الاقتراض): *computer* → كمبيوتر
2. **Calque** (النسخ): *skyscraper* → ناطحة سحاب
3. **Literal translation** (الترجمة الحرفية): *The book is on the table.* → الكتاب على الطاولة
4. **Transposition** (الإبدال): *after his arrival* → بعد أن وصل
5. **Modulation** (التحويل): *It is not difficult.* → إنه سهل
6. **Equivalence** (التكافؤ): *Like father, like son.* → هذا الشبل من ذاك الأسد
7. **Adaptation** (التكييف): *They are like Romeo and Juliet.* → هما كقيس وليلى

The procedures at work

One sentence often needs several procedures:

After his arrival in Kuwait, the minister held a press conference at the Sheraton and said the reforms were not impossible.

بعد أن وصل الوزير إلى الكويت، عقد مؤتمراً صحفياً في فندق شيراتون، وقال إن الإصلاحات ممكنة.

- *after his arrival* → بعد أن وصل: transposition
- *press conference* → مؤتمر صحفي: calque
- *Sheraton* → شيراتون: borrowing
- *not impossible* → ممكنة: modulation

Try it

1. Which procedure? *email* → إيميل
2. Which procedure? *honeymoon* → شهر العسل
3. Which procedure? *It is not easy.* → إنه صعب

Answers

1. Borrowing.
2. Calque.
3. Modulation.

REMEMBER

- Procedures 1–3 are direct; 4–7 are oblique.
- Learn their names: you will use them in your commentary (Chapter 25).

Chapter 13: Translation strategies

In this chapter. The seven procedures work on small units. A strategy is a wider plan for solving a translation problem. This chapter presents the strategies in the course materials and adds others that translators commonly use.

KEY TERMS

- **Translation strategy** (استراتيجية الترجمة): A planned solution to a translation problem.
- **Functional translation** (الترجمة الوظيفية): Translating with a target-language expression that has the same function.
- **Cultural substitution** (الإبدال الثقافي): Replacing a cultural reference with one that is familiar to the target reader.
- **Addition** (الإضافة): Adding words or information that the reader needs.
- **Omission** (الحذف): Leaving out words that are unnecessary in the target language.
- **Explanatory translation** (الترجمة الشرحية): Explaining a word or expression that has no equivalent.
- **Compensation** (التعويض): Making up for an effect lost in one place by creating a similar effect elsewhere.
- **Domestication** (التوطين): Making a translation feel local to the target reader.
- **Foreignisation** (التغريب): Keeping the foreign flavour of the source text.

Strategies from the course materials

1. **Literal and idiomatic translation:** translating an idiom with another idiom when possible. Literal translation often fails: *key word* is better translated *كلمة دالة* or *كلمة مفتاحية* than word by word, depending on the field.
2. **Functional translation:** *spill the beans* → يُفشي السرّ / *mark my words* → تذكر كلامي.
3. **Cultural substitution:** *They are like Romeo and Juliet.* → هما كقيس وليلى.
4. **Addition:** common from English into Arabic, because Arabic is a language of elaboration (لغة إسهاب). *the Fed* → مجلس الاحتياطي الفيدرالي الأمريكي.
5. **Omission:** common from Arabic into English, where repeated synonyms sound unnatural. *شجاع ومغوار* → *very brave*. Omission is also used for politeness. Never omit real information, and never add information to titles.
6. **Explanatory translation:** the last option, used for cultural words and technical terms such as *الصدقة*, *الزكاة*, and *العِدَّة* (Chapter 15).

Other useful strategies

Here are some more strategies that translators often use (Baker, 2018):

1. **A more general word:** when the target language has no exact word. *prawns* and *shrimps* → روبيان.
2. **A more neutral word:** when the source word carries a feeling that would sound wrong in the target text.
3. **Paraphrase:** explaining the meaning with other words. *jet lag* → إرهاق السفر.
4. **Loan word plus explanation:** *waqf* (a charitable endowment in Islam).
5. **Compensation:** if a pun or a rhyme is lost in one sentence, create a similar effect in another place (Dickins et al., 2016).

Domestication and foreignisation

For the text as a whole, you have two choices. **Domestication** makes it feel local to the reader: *a men's evening gathering*. **Foreignisation** keeps its foreign flavour: *the diwaniya* (Venuti, 1995). Let the brief decide (Chapter 2).

Try it

1. Which strategy? شجاع ومغوار → *very brave*
2. Which strategy? *Romeo and Juliet* → قيس وليلى
3. Why is addition common from English into Arabic?

Answers

1. Omission.
2. Cultural substitution.
3. Because Arabic is a language of elaboration, and Arab readers may need extra information.

REMEMBER

- Choose a strategy for each problem, not one strategy for the whole text.
- Explanatory translation is the last option.
- Decide, with the brief, whether the text should feel local or foreign.

Part 5: Culture and new words

Words carry culture, and some words have no equivalent at all. Part 5 shows how to bring cultural meaning close to your reader, how to explain words that have no equivalent, and how new words are created.

Chapter 14: Cultural approximation

In this chapter. In Chapter 1 you learned that translation is approximation. This chapter looks at the most difficult kind: cultural meaning. It builds on the strategies in Chapter 13, especially cultural substitution.

KEY TERMS

- **Cultural approximation** (التقريب الثقافي): Bringing the cultural meaning of the source text as close as possible to the target reader.
- **Culture-specific item** (عنصر ثقافي خاص): A word, custom or reference that belongs to one culture.

What is cultural approximation?

To approximate a meaning is to bring it as close as possible to the target language.

Cultural approximation requires cultural knowledge of both the source language and the target language. When an image or expression carries a different feeling in the other culture, translate the feeling, not the picture.

Expressions with a cultural equivalent

- *I have got the test in the bag.* → الامتحان في جيبِي (it is guaranteed)
- *Like mother, like daughter.* → اقلب الجرّة على فمها تطلع البنت لأُمّها
- *Ali and Ahmad are cut from the same cloth.* → عليّ وأحمد من طينة واحدة
- *a scapegoat* → كبش الفداء
- *to sleep like a log* → نام كالقتيل
- *as busy as a bee* → مشغول جداً; colloquial speakers may say أمّ العروس

When climate changes meaning

The news warmed my heart becomes أثلج الخبرُ صدري. In a hot climate, relief feels cold, not warm. For the same reason, a translator of Shakespeare's line "Shall I compare thee

to a summer's day?" (Shakespeare, 1609) may choose spring for Arab readers: أَشْبَهَكَ
بِیَوْمِ رَبِيعِي؟

Titles and institutions

Official titles differ from country to country. Translate the job, not the words:

- the Home Office (UK) → وزارة الداخلية البريطانية
- the Chancellor of the Exchequer (UK) → وزير المالية البريطاني
- the Secretary of the Treasury (US) → وزير الخزانة الأمريكي
- the Secretary of State (US) → وزير الخارجية الأمريكي
- sheriff (US) → مأمور الشرطة

Culture in the media and business

- watchdog press → الصحافة الرقابية; lapdog press → الصحافة الموالية
- mocktail (a drink without alcohol) → مشروب مُنعش بلا كحول
- product cannibalisation (a marketing term: a new product takes sales from another product of the same company) → منتج يزاحم منتجاً آخر للشركة نفسها

Social expressions

For greetings, thanks and condolences, use the phrase that people actually say in the same situation. Choose the variety of Arabic that suits your reader:

- God willing. → إن شاء الله
- We are very well. → الحمد لله، بخير
- Welcome! It is an honour to have you here. → أهلاً وسهلاً، شَرَّفْتُمُونَا
- I am sorry for your loss. → عَظُمَ اللهُ أَجْرَكُمْ (formal); in Egyptian Arabic, البقية في حياتك
- Thank you for your hard work. → يعطيك العافية (Gulf and Levantine spoken Arabic)

Try it

1. Translate: *cut from the same cloth*
2. Translate: *the Secretary of State* (US)
3. Why does *warmed my heart* become *أثلج صدري*?

Answers

1. من طينة واحدة.
2. وزير الخارجية الأمريكي.
3. Because in a hot climate, relief and happiness are linked with coolness, not warmth.

REMEMBER

- Translate the effect, not the image.
- Use the expression a target-language speaker would use in the same situation.

Chapter 15: Descriptive translation

In this chapter. Sometimes cultural approximation is impossible, because the target language has no word and no similar custom. This chapter explains descriptive translation, the strategy for these words.

KEY TERMS

- **Descriptive translation** (الترجمة الوصفية): An explanatory strategy in which a source expression is paraphrased by describing its meaning. Also called explanatory translation.
- **Transliteration** (النقل الصوتي): Writing the sounds of a word in the letters of another language.
- **Concept** (المفهوم): A complex meaning or idea.

How to do it

1. **Transliterate** the source word, for example *zakat*.
2. **Describe** its meaning in the target language, in brackets after the word or in a footnote.
3. Do this **only the first time** the word appears. After that, the transliterated word is enough.

Descriptive translation is the last option, because it makes the text longer. Use it for cultural words and technical terms that carry a dense meaning.

Examples

- الزكاة → *zakat* (compulsory charity in Islam, paid when certain income conditions are met)
- التيمم → *tayammum* (ritual washing with clean earth when water is scarce or missing)
- البسملة → *the basmala* (saying “In the name of God, the Most Gracious, the Most Merciful”)
- الحوقلة → *the hawqala* (saying “There is no power and no strength except with God”)
- العدة → *idda* (the waiting period before a divorced or widowed woman may remarry)
- العطوة → *atwa* (a temporary truce in tribal customary law, for example in Jordan)
- أُدخل عليّ مستشفى للأمراض النفسية بموجب القانون (UK) → *Ali has been sectioned.*

Try it

1. Translate for English readers: الوقف
2. Where can you put the description?

Answers

1. *waqf* (a charitable endowment in Islam).
2. In brackets after the word, or in a footnote.

REMEMBER

- Transliterate first, then describe.
- Describe only the first time a word appears.
- Use it as the last option.

Chapter 16: Lexical creation

In this chapter. Descriptive translation explains a missing word. Lexical creation goes further: it creates a new word. This chapter explains why and how translators coin new words.

KEY TERMS

- **Lexical creation** (النحت المعجمي): The deliberate coinage of new words or expressions in the target language for items that have no direct equivalent.
- **Neologism** (اللفظ المستحدث): A completely new word.
- **Loan translation (calque)** (الترجمة المستعارة): Translating the parts of a compound word one by one.

Why new words are needed

Some concepts are embedded in a cultural, religious, political or technical context and have no equivalent in the target language, because of a gap in its vocabulary. In such cases the translator sometimes works as a coiner of new words.

Five ways to create a word

1. **Neologism**: inventing a new word. *blog* → مدوّنة
2. **Loan translation (calque)**: *smartphone* → الهاتف الذكي; *shadow government* → حكومة الظل; *Valentine's Day* → عيد الحب; *Thanksgiving* → عيد الشكر
3. **Transliteration** with a short definition: الوقف → *waqf*; الصكوك → *sukuk* (Islamic financial certificates); *radio* → الراديو
4. **Explanation**: *greenwashing* → التضليل البيئي (when companies falsely claim that their products are environmentally friendly)
5. **Hybrid form**: *cybersecurity* → الأمن السيبراني

Search before you create

Before you coin a word, search for an accepted term. The Arabic language academies, UNTERM (United Nations, n.d.) and Arabterm (ALECSO & GIZ, n.d.) record many new terms. For example: *global warming* → الاحترار العالمي; *greenhouse effect* → الاحتباس الحراري; *cancel culture* → ثقافة الإلغاء. An accepted term is always better than a new invention. When a new word becomes official, it is lexicalised (التعجيم).

Try it

1. Which method? *smartphone* → الهاتف الذكي

2. What should you do before creating a new word?

Answers

1. Loan translation (calque).
2. Search for an accepted term in the academies, UNTERM or Arabterm.

REMEMBER

- Create a new word only when no accepted term exists.
- The five methods: neologism, calque, transliteration, explanation and hybrid form.

Part 6: Working with whole texts

So far you have worked mostly with words, phrases and sentences. Part 6 moves to whole texts: how to analyse a text before translating it, how different types of text work, and how words can show a point of view.

Chapter 17: Text analysis

In this chapter. In Chapter 2 you learned to read a text before translating it. This chapter turns that reading into a full analysis, the first of the three phases of translation: analysis, translation and commentary.

KEY TERMS

- **Text** (النص): Anything written: a word, a sentence, a paragraph or more.
- **Text analysis** (تحليل النص): Breaking down and studying a text before translating it.
- **Genre** (الجنس النصي): The type of text, such as a news report, a contract or a poem.
- **Tone** (النبرة): The writer's attitude: neutral, critical, friendly, straightforward.
- **Field** (المجال): The subject area of a text, such as politics, health or law.

Why analyse before translating?

- With every new reading, new ideas emerge.
- You identify the field, the audience of both the original and the translation, the time, the purpose, the tone and the genre.
- You find difficult terms in advance, which makes translation faster.
- You choose your strategies and decide whether you need more resources.
- You form a mental draft of the translation (Nord, 2005).

Newmark gives the same advice: begin “by reading the original for two purposes: first, to understand what it is about; second, to analyse it from a ‘translator’s’ point of view” (Newmark, 1988, Chapter 2).

Analysis is not a summary

A **summary** presents only the facts: what the text is about. An **analysis** identifies the features, background and main ideas of the text: who wrote it, for whom, why and how. When you are asked to analyse, do not summarise or paraphrase.

The analysis checklist

Answer these questions for every text:

1. Who is the author or speaker?
2. Who published it?
3. What is the field?
4. What is the genre and the purpose?
5. What is the tone, and what is the style of writing?
6. Who is the target audience?
7. Which terms and words need checking?
8. Which strategies will you use?

An example

Here is an analysis of a short KUNA news report about relations with Australia. **Field:** politics. **Tone:** straightforward. **Publisher:** KUNA. **Audience:** readers interested in Kuwait and the Middle East. **Style:** formal, with no short forms. **Strategy:** mostly literal, because the text has no metaphors.

A good analyst

- is a careful critic who keeps training his or her analytical skills;
- builds his or her own model of analysis;
- makes sure that the translation matches the analysis: if you describe the tone as formal, your translation must be formal;
- mentions the problems of the text in the analysis, so that the commentary can explain the solutions.

A blank analysis worksheet is included in the Checklists section.

Try it

1. What is the difference between an analysis and a summary?
2. Name the three phases of translation.

Answers

1. A summary gives the facts of the text; an analysis describes its features, background, purpose and style.
2. Analysis, translation and commentary.

REMEMBER

- Analyse **before** you translate.
- Your translation must match your analysis.

Chapter 18: Text types and genres

In this chapter. Your analysis in Chapter 17 asked, “What is the genre?” This chapter explains why the answer matters, and gives an example of each main genre.

KEY TERMS

- **Text type** (نوع النص): A group of texts with the same main function: to inform, to express or to persuade.
- **Genre** (الجنس النصي): A familiar kind of text with its own rules, such as a news report or a recipe.

Three main functions

Katharina Reiss groups texts by their main function (Reiss, 2000). **Informative** texts give facts. **Expressive** texts express feelings and creativity. **Operative** texts try to persuade the reader. Each genre has its own rules, and your translation must follow the rules of the same genre in the target language.

Main genres, with examples

- **News:** facts, neutral tone and short headlines. *Oil prices rose sharply on Monday.* → ارتفعت أسعار النفط ارتفاعاً حاداً يوم الاثنين.
- **Legal:** exact words; *shall* expresses an obligation. *This Agreement shall be governed by the laws of the State of Kuwait.* → تخضع هذه الاتفاقية لقوانين دولة الكويت.
- **Political:** careful, sensitive words. *The two sides held frank and constructive talks.* → أجرى الجانبان محادثات صريحة وبناءة.
- **Medical:** no ambiguity and exact doses. *Take one tablet twice daily.* → تناول قرصاً واحداً مرتين يومياً.
- **Technical:** clear instructions and consistent terms. *Press and hold the power button.* → اضغط مطوّلاً على زرّ التشغيل.
- **Literary:** feeling, voice and natural dialogue. *It has been a long day.* → لقد كان يوماً شاقاً.
- **Poetry:** images and rhythm, with more freedom. *al-Mutanabbi, n.d.)* → *The horses, the night and the desert know me.*
- **Advertising:** persuasion and rhythm. *Save more. Smile more.* → وقر أكثر... وابتسم أكثر!

Try it

1. Which text type is an advert: informative, expressive or operative?

2. Why does a medical text need exact words?

Answers

1. Operative: it tries to persuade.
2. Because a mistake, such as a wrong dose, can harm the reader.

REMEMBER

- Identify the genre before you translate.
- Follow the rules of the same genre in the target language.

Chapter 19: Words and points of view

In this chapter. Some texts do more than give facts: their words also show a point of view. This chapter shows you how to notice these words and what to do about them, using three simple questions based on Norman Fairclough's model.

KEY TERMS

- **Ideology** (الأيديولوجيا): A set of beliefs that shapes how people describe events.
- **Loaded word** (كلمة مشحونة): A word that carries a judgement, positive or negative.

No word is neutral

The same event can be described in different words, and each choice shows a point of view. Your translation can keep, soften or strengthen that view, so choose carefully. Clients often have a policy on sensitive words: follow it (Chapter 1).

- *A suicide bomber killed ten people.* The Arabic may be انتحاري or استشهادي, depending on the client's policy. The two words describe the same person from opposite points of view.
- *regime or government* (حكومة or نظام): "regime" is negative.
- *Protesters were killed.* (قُتل متظاهرون): the passive hides who did the killing.

Three questions to ask

The linguist Norman Fairclough (1992) shows that language is connected to power and society. His model gives you three simple questions:

1. **The words:** which words show a judgement? Who is shown doing what, and who is hidden?
2. **The writer:** who wrote the text, for which newspaper or organisation, and for which readers?
3. **The purpose:** whose interests does the text serve?

Checklist 3 at the end of the book turns these questions into a checklist.

Try it

1. Why is *regime* not neutral?
2. What does the passive in *Protesters were killed* hide?

Answers

1. It suggests a harsh or illegitimate government.
2. Who did the killing.

REMEMBER

- Notice loaded words and hidden doers.
- Follow the client's policy, and explain sensitive choices in your commentary.

Part 7: Tools and resources

Good translators use good tools. Part 7 explains how to use printed and digital dictionaries, how to manage terminology, and how to use machine translation and AI safely.

Chapter 20: Printed and digital dictionaries

In this chapter. You have already met many words whose first dictionary meaning is wrong. This chapter shows which dictionaries to use and how to use them well.

KEY TERMS

- **Bilingual dictionary** (معجم ثنائي اللغة): A dictionary that gives equivalents in another language.
- **Monolingual dictionary** (معجم أحادي اللغة): A dictionary that explains words in the same language.
- **Specialised dictionary** (معجم متخصص): A dictionary for one field, such as law or medicine.
- **Collocations dictionary** (معجم المتلازمات): A dictionary of the natural word partners of a language.

A dictionary gives options, not answers

Samuel Johnson wrote one of the first great English dictionaries. In a letter of 1784 he said: “Dictionaries are like watches; the worst is better than none, and the best cannot be expected to go quite true” (Johnson, 1784/1897). Never take the first meaning a dictionary gives. Use the three-check rule:

1. Find the options in a **bilingual dictionary**.
2. Confirm the meaning in a **monolingual dictionary**.
3. See how the word is really used in a text written in the target language.

For example, for *a fast colour* a bilingual dictionary gives ثابت and سريع. An Arabic dictionary confirms that ثابت can mean “not fading”, and clothing labels use لون ثابت. So the answer is لون ثابت.

Printed and digital dictionaries

- **Printed dictionaries** are edited by experts and give full entries with examples, but they are slower to use and may not include new words.

- **Digital dictionaries** are fast, easy to search and often updated, but their quality varies. Always check who publishes them. A digital version of a well-known printed dictionary is safer than an unknown website.

Useful dictionaries

- *Al-Mawrid* (Baalbaki, n.d.): English–Arabic and Arabic–English, for everyday words.
- *A Dictionary of Modern Written Arabic* (Wehr, 1994): Arabic words listed by root.
- *Al-Muʿjam al-Wasīṭ* (المعجم الوسيط) (Academy of the Arabic Language, n.d.): Arabic meanings.
- *Oxford Collocations Dictionary for Students of English* (2009): natural English word partners.
- UNTERM (United Nations, n.d.) and Arabterm (ALECSO & GIZ, n.d.): official and technical terms.

Try it

1. Which dictionary do you use to confirm a meaning?
2. What should you check before trusting a digital dictionary?

Answers

1. A monolingual dictionary.
2. Who publishes it.

REMEMBER

- Check in a bilingual dictionary, then a monolingual one, then a real text.
- Use printed and digital dictionaries together, and check digital sources.

Chapter 21: Terminology and terminology management

In this chapter. Chapter 20 showed you how to find the meaning of a word. Specialised texts need more: exact terms, used the same way every time. This chapter explains what terminology is and how to manage terms. It is based on the Translation Team's terminology chapter and on Cabré (1999).

KEY TERMS

- **Term** (المصطلح): A word or expression that names a concept in a special field.
- **Terminology** (علم المصطلح): The study, collection and management of specialised terms.
- **Terminologist** (المصطلحي): A specialist who creates and standardises terms, usually in one language.
- **Term list** (قائمة المصطلحات): A list of the approved terms for a project, with their translations.
- **Termbase** (قاعدة بيانات المصطلحات): A database of terms and information about them.
- **Terminology guide** (دليل المصطلحات): A document that tells translators which terms to use for a client.

What is terminology?

Every field, such as law, medicine or engineering, has its own **terms**. A term names one exact concept. One wrong term can change the meaning of a contract or a medical instruction.

Terminology is the study of these terms: how they are collected, named and managed (Cabré, 1999). You do not need to be an expert in it, but you do need to handle terms carefully.

The translator and the terminologist

- A **translator** works across two languages and uses terms: from glossaries, specialised dictionaries and term databases.
- A **terminologist** usually works within one language and creates and standardises terms.
- When no dictionary gives you the term you need, you must think like a terminologist and create an accurate term yourself (Chapter 16).

Why manage terms?

If terms are not managed, the same concept gets different names. The reader is confused, earlier translations cannot be reused, and the work becomes slower and more expensive. Once a term is widely accepted, do not change it without a good reason.

Types of terms

Short forms

- **Initialism:** letters read one by one: *CIA*, *CBC* (complete blood count).
- **Acronym:** letters read as a word: *LASER*.
- **Abbreviation:** part of a word: *vol.* (volume).
- **Clipping:** the first part of a word: *super* (superintendent).

What makes a good term?

A good term is clear, short and has only one meaning. It should also follow the normal rules for making words in the language.

The Arabic language academies

The Arabic language academies (مجامع اللغة العربية), for example in Cairo, Baghdad and Amman, create and approve Arabic terms (Translation Team, n.d.). Check their lists before you create a term of your own.

How to translate a term

1. **Understand** the term and its exact meaning in its field.
2. **Look at its origin:** the parts of a term often explain it.
3. **Find the equivalent** in reliable sources: the academies, UNTERM, Arabterm and the client's guide. If none exists, create one (Chapter 16).
4. **Record** it in your term list, and **share** the list with your team.

A simple term list

English term	Arabic term	Field	Note
<i>governing law</i>	القانون الواجب التطبيق	Legal	القانون المطبق; not القانون الحاكم
<i>provided that</i>	شريطة أن	Legal	A condition in a contract
<i>Article (of a law)</i>	مادة	Legal	A contract <i>clause</i> is بند

English term	Arabic term	Field	Note
CBC	تعداد الدم الكامل	Medical	صورة الدم الكاملة Also

Tools for terms

- **Technical dictionary:** the approved terms of one subject.
- **Termbase:** an online database. Each entry holds the term in each language, with its definition, field, source and date. It is quick to search and update, and a team can share it.
- **Terminology guide:** the client's list of approved terms and writing rules. Always ask whether one exists, and follow it.

The golden rule: one term for one idea

Use the same term all the way through a text. If you translate *Article* as مَادَّة in the first paragraph, do not change to بند later “for variety”. A new word makes the reader think of a new meaning.

Try it

1. What is the difference between a translator and a terminologist?
2. Is *LASER* an initialism or an acronym?
3. What should you do when no dictionary gives you the term?

Answers

1. A translator works across two languages; a terminologist creates and standardises terms, usually in one language.
2. An acronym: the letters are read as a word.
3. Think like a terminologist: understand the term, create an accurate equivalent, and record it.

REMEMBER

- Keep a term list for every project, and ask for the client's guide.
- Search the academies, UNTERM and Arabterm before you create a term.
- Use one term for one idea.

Chapter 22: Machine translation and AI

In this chapter. Dictionaries and term lists help you find words. Machine translation and AI tools go further: they produce whole translations. This chapter explains how to use them safely.

KEY TERMS

- **Machine translation (MT)** (الترجمة الآلية): Translation done by software, such as online translation tools or AI chat tools.
- **Post-editing** (التحرير اللاحق): A human correcting and improving machine translation.
- **Hallucination** (الهلوسة): Information produced by an AI tool that is not in the source text.

Useful or risky?

Machine translation can help with a first draft of a simple text, or with checking your own ideas. It is risky for legal, medical and religious texts, for idioms and poetry, and for any private or confidential text. You, not the machine, are responsible for the final translation (Kenny, 2022).

Typical mistakes

- *It's raining cats and dogs.* → إنها تمطر قططاً وكلاباً: the idiom is translated word by word. Correct: تمطر بغزارة.
- *The doctor said she...* → قال الطبيب...: the machine guessed a man. Correct: قالت الطبيبة....
- AI tools may add facts that are not in the text (hallucination).

Post-editing: the new direction

As the course materials put it, post-editing is now the new direction for translators around the world, and translators must be able to assess translation quality. When you post-edit, compare the machine output with the source sentence by sentence, then read it again as a normal text.

Four rules

1. You are responsible for every word.
2. Never put a client's private text into a public AI tool.
3. Check terms, names, numbers, idioms and every "not".

4. Tell the client if you used a machine or AI.

Try it

1. May you paste a client's confidential contract into a free AI tool?
2. What is post-editing?

Answers

1. No, never.
2. A human correcting and improving machine translation.

REMEMBER

- Machine translation is a first draft, not a final translation.
- Always post-edit, and protect your client's privacy.

Part 8: Checking and explaining

A translation is not finished when you write the last word. Part 8 shows you how to revise your work and avoid common mistakes, how to assess risks, and how to explain your choices in a commentary.

Chapter 23: Revision and common mistakes

In this chapter. Every chapter so far has helped you write a better translation. This chapter shows you how to check it. It also collects the most common grammatical and stylistic mistakes in one place, so that you can use it as a reference.

KEY TERMS

- **Draft** (المسودة): The first version of a translation.
- **Revision** (المراجعة): Checking a translation against the source and correcting it.

Three readings

Your first version is a draft. Every translator makes mistakes in a draft, even experts; revision is where you find them (Mossop, 2014).

1. **With the original:** is anything missing, added or changed?
2. **Without the original:** does it sound natural? If a sentence sounds translated, rewrite it.
3. **The details:** numbers, names, spelling, punctuation, titles and captions.

Common mistakes in Arabic (EN → AR)

- Starting with the subject: ...أعلنت الحكومة → أعلنت الحكومة
- Overusing the Kuwaiti verb: قام بـ: قام الوزير بزيارة الكويت → زار الوزير الكويت
- Copying the English passive: تم افتتاح المعرض من قبل الوزير → افتتح الوزير المعرض
- Numbers 3 to 10: ثلاث طلاب → ثلاثة طلاب
- Hamza and taa marbuta: إنشاء، مدرسه، الى → إنشاء، مدرسة، إلى
- Word-for-word collocations: كسر القانون → خالف القانون
- English punctuation: نعم، شكراً؟ → نعم، شكراً؟

Common mistakes in English (AR → EN)

- Very long sentences joined with “and”: split them with full stops.
- Repeated synonyms: *brave and daring* → *very brave*
- An extra “the”: *The life is beautiful.* → *Life is beautiful.*
- A missing “is”: *He in the office.* → *He is in the office.*
- Arabic prepositions: *He married from her.* → *He married her.*
- Missing capital letters: *the minister of health* → *the Minister of Health*

Try it

1. Improve: قام المدير بتوقيع العقد.
2. Improve: *She is a doctor in the hospital and she works hard and she likes her job.*

Answers

1. وقَّع المديرُ العقدَ.
2. *She is a doctor at the hospital. She works hard and likes her job.*

REMEMBER

- Read your translation once **without** the original.
- If a sentence sounds translated, rewrite it.

Chapter 24: Interlingual risk assessment

In this chapter. Revision finds mistakes. Risk assessment tells you where to look hardest. This chapter presents a simple risk matrix for translation between English and Arabic.

KEY TERMS

- **Risk (الخطر):** The chance that a translation choice causes a problem, and how serious that problem would be.
- **Risk management (إدارة المخاطر):** Spending more effort where a mistake could cause more harm.
- **Risk matrix (مصفوفة تقييم المخاطر):** A table that lists possible risks, how serious they are, and what to do about them.

Why assess risk?

Some mistakes are small; others can cause real harm, such as a wrong dose in a medicine leaflet or a missing “not” in a contract. Anthony Pym describes translating as risk management: the more serious the possible harm, the more care a text needs (Pym, 2015).

The interlingual risk matrix

Risk area	Example	Risk level	What to do
Terms	<i>governing law</i> → القانون الحاكم	High in legal texts	Check a specialised dictionary and the term list
Negatives	A lost “not” reverses the meaning	High	Compare sentence by sentence
Numbers and dates	A wrong dose; Hijri or Gregorian date	High	Check every figure twice
Legal verbs	<i>shall</i> → سوف	High in contracts	Use the Arabic present tense for obligations
Sensitive names	<i>Persian Gulf / Arabian Gulf</i>	Medium to high	Follow the client’s policy; explain in the commentary
Ideological words	انتحاري / استشهادي	Medium to high	Follow the client’s policy (Chapter 19)
Cultural images	<i>warmed my heart</i> → أدفأ قلبي	Medium	Use cultural approximation (Chapter 14)
Words with several meanings	علم: flag, knowledge or “taught”?	Medium	Read the context (Chapter 6)

Risk area	Example	Risk level	What to do
Style and register	A dialect word in a formal report	Low to medium	Re-read with the brief in mind
Idioms	An idiom translated word by word	Low to medium	Check whether it is an idiom (Chapter 8)

How to use the matrix

1. Before you deliver, go through each row and find any risky places in your translation.
2. Give the most time to the high-risk areas.
3. For high-risk texts, such as legal and medical ones, ask a second person to check your translation.

For example: *This Agreement shall be governed by the laws of the State of Kuwait.* →
 (سوف تخضع not). تخضع هذه الاتفاقية لقوانين دولة الكويت

Try it

1. What is the main risk in *Take one tablet twice daily*?
2. What should you do with a high-risk text?

Answers

1. The dose: the numbers must be exactly right.
2. Check it with extra care, and ask a second person to review it.

REMEMBER

- Check numbers, names, negatives, terms and legal verbs every time.
- The higher the risk, the more careful the check.

Chapter 25: Translation commentary

In this chapter. This last chapter brings everything together. Analysis (Chapter 17) was the first phase of translation, and translation the second. The commentary is the third: it explains and justifies your choices, using the names of the procedures and strategies you have learned.

KEY TERMS

- **Translation commentary** (التعليق على الترجمة): A text that explains the problems in a translation and justifies the solutions.
- **Justification** (التبرير): The reason why a translation choice is right.

What a commentary is for

A commentary shows your thinking, like showing your working in a maths exam. It improves your critical skills and your reasoning, and it helps you judge translations, your own and other people's (Dickins et al., 2016).

Two parts

1. **Reflecting on your analysis:** what did the analysis show, and which problems did it identify?
2. **Reflecting on your translation:** how did you solve each problem?

Five steps for each problem

1. **The problem:** what was difficult?
2. **The solution:** what did you write?
3. **The procedure or strategy:** which technique did you use (Chapters 9 to 16)?
4. **The resource:** which dictionary or source did you check?
5. **The justification:** why is your choice right for the reader?

Rules

- Write in the **third person**: "The translator faced...", "The translator changed some parts to make them more comprehensible..."
- Use WH-questions to guide you: what, why, how?
- Always give examples from the source and the translation.

- Explain omissions, for example: “This was omitted due to its irrelevance to the target audience.”
- Mention the dictionaries and resources you used.
- Keep it short and clear.

An example

The source text says the agreement “remained a dead letter”. A literal translation, حرفاً ميتاً, would confuse Arab readers, so the translator chose the functional equivalent حبراً على ورق. The expression was checked in Arabic newspapers. It is a familiar idiom and suits the formal style of a news report.

Try it

1. Write one commentary sentence for *strong tea* → شاي ثقيل.

Answers

1. For example: “*Strong tea* is a collocation, so it could not be translated word by word; the translator used the Arabic partner شاي ثقيل, which sounds natural to Arab readers.”

REMEMBER

- Analysis → translation → commentary.
- For each problem: problem, solution, procedure or strategy, resource, justification.

Part 9: Audiovisual translation

Part 9 is the most advanced part of the handbook. It applies what you have learned to films, television, video games and online video, where words, images and sound work together. It is based on the Translation Team's audiovisual translation course notes.

Chapter 26: Introduction to audiovisual translation

In this chapter. So far you have translated written texts. Audiovisual texts add pictures and sound, and they set limits of time and space. This chapter explains what audiovisual translation is, its main types, one useful idea, and its challenges.

KEY TERMS

- **Audiovisual translation (AVT)** (الترجمة السمعية البصرية): Translating texts that combine words, images and sound, such as films and video games.
- **Dubbing** (الدبلجة): Replacing the original dialogue with recorded dialogue in the target language.
- **Voice-over** (التعليق الصوتي): Recording a translation over the original voice, which can still be heard quietly.
- **Audio description** (الوصف الصوتي): A spoken description of what happens on screen, for blind viewers.
- **Skopos theory** (نظرية الغاية): The idea that the purpose of a translation decides how it is translated.

Why AVT matters

Films, series, games and online videos are part of almost everyone's life today (Pérez-González, 2014). AVT has become one of the fastest-growing areas of Translation Studies, with more research, courses and conferences every year. The reason is technology: AVT and technology go hand in hand.

What makes AVT different?

- It depends completely on technology.
- It combines three elements: **images**, **sound** (dialogue, music, sound effects) and **written words** on screen. They work together to make meaning.
- The translator must connect the words with the pictures and sound (Gambier, 2003).

Types of AVT

- **Subtitling:** written text on the screen (Chapter 27).
- **Dubbing:** new dialogue recorded in the target language, often matching the actors' lips.
- **Voice-over:** a translation read over the original voice, as in documentaries and interviews.
- **Free commentary:** a freer version with additions and comments, as in sports commentary and children's programmes.
- **In-vision signing:** sign language on screen, for deaf viewers.
- **Audio description:** a spoken description of the action, for blind viewers.
- **Audio subtitling:** subtitles read aloud, for blind viewers.
- **Fandubbing** and **fansubbing:** dubbing and subtitles made by fans.

Dubbing

Dubbing is one of the oldest types of AVT. It is used for cartoons, video games and commercials, and in the Arab world for many children's programmes and series. Its main challenges are matching the actors' lip movements, adapting cultural content, and keeping quality and consistency across a whole series.

One useful idea: purpose first

Before you translate a film or a video, ask what it is for and who will watch it. This idea is called **Skopos theory** (Reiss & Vermeer, 1984): the purpose of a translation decides how you translate it. A cartoon for children and a documentary for adults need very different choices, just like the texts in Chapter 2.

Why AVT is challenging

- **Culture:** a reference may have no equivalent (Chapters 14 to 16).
- **Language:** English and Arabic are built differently, so you must be accurate and brief at the same time (Chapter 3).
- **Technology:** subtitles have strict limits of space and time.
- **Creativity:** jokes, wordplay, songs and slang need creative solutions.

AVT in the Arab world

According to the team's course notes (Translation Team, n.d.):

- **Challenges:** AVT is not always clearly defined or supported by institutions, and technology changes quickly.
- **Missed chances:** Arab films could reach more international audiences, websites could reach more visitors, and more content could be made accessible for people with disabilities.
- **Solutions:** closer work between universities and the media industry, and practical training, for example in live subtitling.

Try it

1. What are the three elements of an audiovisual text?
2. Which type of AVT describes the action on screen for blind viewers?
3. What does Skopos theory put first?

Answers

1. Images, sound and written words.
2. Audio description.
3. The purpose of the translation.

REMEMBER

- AVT combines images, sound and words, and depends on technology.
- The main types are subtitling, dubbing, voice-over, free commentary, in-vision signing, audio description and audio subtitling.
- The purpose and the viewers decide how you translate.

Chapter 27: Subtitling

In this chapter. Subtitling is the type of AVT that beginners meet most often. This chapter explains what subtitles are, the main kinds, and how to deal with cultural references and strong language.

KEY TERMS

- **Subtitling** (الترجمة المرئية / السترجة): Showing a written translation of the dialogue at the bottom of the screen.
- **Dialogue list** (قائمة الحوار): A written script of everything said in a film, given to the translator.
- **Culture-bound term** (مصطلح ذو خصوصية ثقافية): A reference to something that belongs to one culture, such as a food or a holiday.
- **Taboo language** (اللغة المحظورة): Words that a society or religion forbids or restricts, such as swear words.
- **Censorship** (الرقابة): Removing or changing content that is considered unacceptable.

What is a subtitle?

A subtitle is a short written translation at the bottom of the screen. It has at most two lines. Traditionally each line holds about 37 to 39 characters, and streaming platforms now allow up to 42 (Díaz Cintas & Remael, 2021). Always follow the client's guidelines.

Kinds of subtitles

- **Intralingual**: the same language as the dialogue, for example for deaf viewers.
- **Interlingual**: another language. This is what translators usually make.
- **Bilingual**: two languages on screen at once.
- **Pre-prepared** (offline) or **live** (online), as in live news.
- **Open** (burned into the picture) or **closed** (can be turned on and off).
- Also: **surtitles** in theatres, **intertitles** in silent films, and **fansubs** made by fans.

Words, images and sound

A film sends meaning through words on screen, images, dialogue, and music and sound effects. A good subtitle works with all of them:

- If the picture already shows something, the subtitle can be shorter.
- If the picture is unclear, the subtitle can explain it.
- Subtitles are short, so they rely on the images and the story to stay clear.

Why subtitling is hard

- Viewers can hear the original and read your translation at the same time, so they notice mistakes.
- Speech becomes writing, and it must be cut down to short lines.
- The way characters speak shows who they are: their **sociolect** (social group), **slang** and **idiolect** (personal habits). Try to keep this.

Cultural references

Cultural references may be **geographical** (places), **ethnographic** (food, holidays, daily life) or **socio-political** (government, institutions) (Díaz Cintas & Remael, 2007).

Díaz Cintas and Remael (2007) and Pedersen (2011) describe similar strategies for them. The most useful are:

1. **Loan** (retention): keep the source word.
2. **Calque** (direct translation): translate it word for word.
3. **Explicitation** (specification): add a little information to make it clear.
4. **Generalisation**: use a more general word.
5. **Substitution**: replace it with something familiar to the target audience.
6. **Official equivalent**: use the accepted translation, if there is one.
7. **Compensation**: make up for a lost effect somewhere else.
8. **Omission**: leave it out, when it is not important and there is no space.

You met most of these strategies in Chapters 12 and 13. The difference is that in subtitling you must also respect limits of space and time.

Strong and taboo language

Taboo language, such as swearing, is used in films for realism, to show character, or for humour. Subtitlers often soften it because of **censorship**: rules set by broadcasters or authorities, or the translator's own choice (self-censorship). Follow the client's guidelines, and keep the emotion of the scene where you can.

Try it

1. What is the difference between open and closed subtitles?
2. Which strategy uses an accepted translation?

3. Why do viewers notice mistakes in subtitles easily?

Answers

1. Open subtitles are burned into the picture; closed subtitles can be turned on and off.
2. The official equivalent.
3. Because they can hear the original and read the translation at the same time.

REMEMBER

- A subtitle has at most two short lines and must work with the images and sound.
- Choose a strategy for each cultural reference, within the limits of space and time.
- Follow the client's guidelines on strong language.

Practice

These exercises bring together everything in the handbook. They are arranged in three levels, from single sentences to full texts, and cover several genres. The chapter number after each item tells you where to look for help. Use the checklists as you work, and check your answers in the Answer key.

Level 1: Sentences

A. Translate into Arabic (EN → AR)

1. *She paid a visit to her grandmother.* (Chapter 7)
2. *The agreement has remained a dead letter.* (Chapter 9)
3. *He is a heavy smoker.* (Chapter 4)
4. *It's raining cats and dogs.* (Chapter 8)
5. *The Home Office issued a statement.* (Chapter 14)

B. Translate into English (AR → EN)

1. رجع بخُفِّي حُنين. (Chapter 8)
2. أثلَجَ الخبرُ صدري. (Chapter 14)
3. هو شجاعٌ مِغوار. (Chapter 13)
4. يساورني القلق بشأن النتائج. (Chapter 7)
5. قدّم الوزير استقالته أمس. (Chapter 3)

C. Each translation has one mistake. Find it and correct it.

1. *Pay attention, please.* → ادفع الانتباه من فضلك. (Chapter 7)
2. *The government announced new measures.* → الحكومة أعلنت إجراءاتٍ جديدة. (Chapter 3)
3. *I have three brothers.* → لدي ثلاث إخوة. (Chapter 3)
4. *The life is beautiful.* → الحياة جميلة. (Chapter 23)
5. *He married from her last year.* → تزوّج منها العام الماضي. (Chapter 23)

Level 2: Short texts

For each text: (1) write the brief (client, purpose, audience), (2) translate the text, and (3) write two sentences of commentary explaining your main choice.

Text 2a: a legal and human-rights text (EN → AR)

All human beings are born free and equal in dignity and rights. They are endowed with reason and conscience and should act towards one another in a spirit of brotherhood.

Source: Universal Declaration of Human Rights, Article 1 (United Nations, 1948). When you have finished, compare your version with the official Arabic text.

Text 2b: classical poetry (AR → EN)

الخيْلُ والليلُ والبيداءُ تعرفني ... والسيْفُ والرمحُ والقرطاسُ والقلمُ

Source: al-Mutanabbi (n.d.). Try to keep the rhythm of the list.

Text 2c: English poetry (EN → AR)

Shall I compare thee to a summer's day? Thou art more lovely and more temperate.

Source: Sonnet 18 (Shakespeare, 1609). Summer or spring? Explain your choice (Chapter 14).

Level 3: Full texts

Work like a professional, in four steps:

1. Analyse the text with the analysis checklist (Chapter 17).
2. Translate it.
3. Revise it with the risk matrix and the checklists (Chapters 23 and 24).
4. Write a commentary of about 150 words (Chapter 25).

Text 3a: news (EN → AR)

Health officials have urged residents to stay indoors between 11 a.m. and 4 p.m. as temperatures are expected to top 50°C this week. "Heatstroke is not something to take lightly," a Ministry of Health spokesperson said, advising people to drink plenty of water and to check on elderly neighbours. Meanwhile, shopping malls are expected to be packed as families seek relief from the heat.

Practice text written for this handbook.

Text 3b: cultural news (AR → EN)

احتفلت الجمعية الثقافية مساء أمس بتكريم نخبة من المترجمين الشباب، وذلك في أمسية حضرها لفيّف من الأدباء والأكاديميين. وأكد رئيس الجمعية في كلمته أنّ الترجمة جسر يصل الشعوب بعضها ببعض، مشيراً إلى أنّ العناية بالمترجمين الشباب واجب لا ترف. واختتمت الأمسية بقراءات شعرية مترجمة، وسط أجواء سادها الودّ والتقدير.

Practice text written for this handbook.

Answer key

These are suggested answers. There is often more than one good translation: any version that is accurate, natural and right for the reader is acceptable.

Level 1

1. زارت جدّتها. "Pay a visit" is a collocation meaning "visit".
2. ظلّت الاتفاقية حبراً على ورق. A functional equivalent.
3. يدخّن بشراهة. The form changes; the meaning stays.
4. تمطر بغزارة. An idiom is never translated word by word.
5. أصدرت وزارة الداخلية البريطانية بياناً. The Home Office is the UK interior ministry.
6. *He came back empty-handed.* The meaning of the proverb, in natural English.
7. *The news warmed my heart.* Arabic "cold" relief becomes English "warmth".
8. *He is very brave.* Omission: English does not need two synonyms.
9. *I am growing worried about the results.* A natural English collocation.
10. *The minister resigned yesterday.* Start with the subject; قدّم استقالته means "resigned".
11. انتبه من فضلك. "Pay attention" is a collocation.
12. أعلنت الحكومة إجراءات جديدة. Start with the verb.
13. لديّ ثلاثة إخوة. With 3 to 10, the number takes the opposite gender.
14. *Life is beautiful.* No "the" before general ideas.
15. *He married her last year.* No Arabic preposition in English.

Level 2

2a. يُولد جميعُ الناسَ أحراراً ومتساوين في الكرامة والحقوق، وقد وهبوا العقلَ والضمير،
وعليهم أن يعامل بعضهم بعضاً بروح الإخاء. Start with the verb and join the two sentences
with و. Then compare your version with the official United Nations Arabic text.

2b. *The horses, the night and the desert know me, as do the sword, the spear, the paper
and the pen.* Keep the list of seven nouns. Words such as *steed* and *parchment* would give
a more classical tone.

2c. *أشبهك بيوم من أيام الربيع؟ أنت أبهى منه وأكثر اعتدالاً.* Spring gives Arab readers the
pleasant feeling that summer gives English readers (cultural approximation).

Level 3: guidance

3a. *top 50°C* → درجة مئوية 50 تتجاوز; *not something to take lightly* → أمرٌ خطير (modulation); *check on* → الاطمئنان على; *packed* → مكتظة. The genre is news, so keep a neutral tone and start sentences with verbs.

3b. A possible opening: *Last night, the Cultural Society honoured a group of outstanding young translators at an evening attended by writers and academics.* Split the long Arabic sentence, keep the image of translation as a bridge, and translate الودّ والتقدير as *a warm, appreciative atmosphere*.

Checklists

Use these practical checklists with every translation. Tick each point as you go.

Checklist 1: The translation process

Before you translate

- ☐ I know the client, the purpose and the audience.
- ☐ I have read the whole text at least twice.
- ☐ I have completed the analysis worksheet.
- ☐ I have listed and checked the key terms.
- ☐ I have my dictionaries and resources ready.

While you translate

- ☐ The meaning is the same as in the original.
- ☐ The terms are the same all the way through.
- ☐ The style suits the brief and the genre.
- ☐ Collocations and idioms sound natural.
- ☐ Cultural references are handled.

After you translate

- ☐ Nothing is missing, and nothing has been added.
- ☐ Every “not” is in place.
- ☐ Numbers, names, dates and captions are correct.
- ☐ Grammar, spelling and punctuation are correct.
- ☐ I have read the translation without the original.
- ☐ I have checked the high-risk areas in the risk matrix.

Checklist 2: Analysis worksheet

Photocopy this page and fill it in before you translate a new text (Chapter 17).

Title of the text: _____

Author or speaker: _____

Publisher: _____

Field: _____

Genre and purpose: _____

Tone and style: _____

Target audience: _____

Terms to check: _____

Cultural items: _____

Strategies I will use: _____

Checklist 3: Words and points of view (based on Fairclough)

Use this checklist for news, political and other sensitive texts (Chapter 19).

The words

- ☐ I have marked words that show a judgement (for example *regime*, *terrorist*, *freedom fighter*).
- ☐ I have noticed who is shown doing what, and who is hidden (for example, by the passive).
- ☐ I have kept, softened or strengthened each loaded word deliberately, not by accident.

The writer

- ☐ I know who wrote the text and who published it.
- ☐ I know which readers it was written for.
- ☐ I know my client's policy on sensitive words and names.

The purpose

- ☐ I have considered whose interests the text serves.
- ☐ I have explained my sensitive choices in the commentary.

Checklist 4: Your commentary

- ☐ Part one reflects on my analysis; part two reflects on my translation.
- ☐ For each problem: problem, solution, procedure or strategy, resource, justification.
- ☐ I quote examples from the source and the translation.
- ☐ I write in the third person.
- ☐ I mention the dictionaries and resources I used.

Future editions

This first edition covers the basics for beginners. The Translation Team plans to develop the handbook further.

Future editions are planned to include:

- an Arabic version of the handbook (Translation Team, n.d.);
- more authentic news texts for practice;
- subtitling exercises with film clips;
- chapters on interpreting, and on legal and medical translation, for more advanced readers.

Glossary

All the key terms defined in this handbook, in alphabetical order, with the chapter where each one is explained.

Adaptation الترجمة المكيفة A very free rewriting, which some specialists regard as a new text rather than a translation. (Chapter 10)

Adaptation (procedure) التكيف Replacing a cultural situation with a familiar one. (Chapter 12)

Addition الإضافة Adding words or information that the reader needs. (Chapter 13)

Approximation التقريب Bringing the meaning of the source text as close as possible to the target language. (Chapter 1)

Audio description الوصف الصوتي A spoken description of what happens on screen, for blind viewers. (Chapter 26)

Audiovisual translation (AVT) الترجمة السمعية البصرية Translating texts that combine words, images and sound, such as films and video games. (Chapter 26)

Bilingual dictionary معجم ثنائي اللغة A dictionary that gives equivalents in another language. (Chapter 20)

Borrowing الاقتراض Taking a word from the source language as it is. (Chapter 12)

Calque النسخ Translating each part of an expression literally. (Chapter 12)

Censorship الرقابة Removing or changing content that is considered unacceptable. (Chapter 27)

Client العميل The person or organisation that asks for a translation. (Chapter 2)

Collocation التلازم اللفظي Words that naturally go together; the company a word keeps. (Chapter 7)

Collocations dictionary معجم المتلازمات A dictionary of the natural word partners of a language. (Chapter 20)

Commissioned translator مترجم بتكليف A translator who works for a client. (Chapter 1)

Communicative purpose الغرض التواصل What the translation is for: to inform, persuade, instruct or entertain. (Chapter 2)

Compensation التعويض Making up for an effect lost in one place by creating a similar effect elsewhere. (Chapter 13)

Concept المفهوم A complex meaning or idea. (Chapter 15)

Connotation المعنى الإيحائي The extra feeling or association a word carries. (Chapter 5)

Context السياق Any background information that helps us understand a text. (Chapter 6)

Cultural approximation التقريب الثقافي Bringing the cultural meaning of the source text as close as possible to the target reader. (Chapter 14)

Cultural substitution الإبدال الثقافي Replacing a cultural reference with one that is familiar to the target reader. (Chapter 13)

Culture-bound term مصطلح ذو خصوصية ثقافية A reference to something that belongs to one culture, such as a food or a holiday. (Chapter 27)

Culture-specific item عنصر ثقافي خاص A word, custom or reference that belongs to one culture. (Chapter 14)

Denotation المعنى المعجمي The basic, dictionary meaning of a word. (Chapter 5)

Descriptive translation الترجمة الوصفية An explanatory strategy in which a source expression is paraphrased by describing its meaning. Also called explanatory translation. (Chapter 15)

Dialect اللهجة العامية The everyday spoken Arabic of a country or region. (Chapter 3)

Dialogue list قائمة الحوار A written script of everything said in a film, given to the translator. (Chapter 27)

Domestication التوطين Making a translation feel local to the target reader. (Chapter 13)

Draft المسودة The first version of a translation. (Chapter 23)

Dubbing الدبلجة Replacing the original dialogue with recorded dialogue in the target language. (Chapter 26)

Equivalence التكافؤ A match between a source-language expression and a target-language expression. (Chapter 9)

Explanatory translation الترجمة الشرحية Explaining a word or expression that has no equivalent. (Chapter 13)

Field المجال The subject area of a text, such as politics, health or law. (Chapter 17)

Figurative language اللغة المجازية Language used in a non-literal way to create an image or effect. (Chapter 11)

Foreignisation التغريب Keeping the foreign flavour of the source text. (Chapter 13)

Form البناء The structure of language: a word, phrase, clause, sentence or text. (Chapter 4)

Formal equivalence التكافؤ الشكلي Keeping the form of the original: passive for passive, verb for verb. (Chapter 9)

Free translation الترجمة الحرة Keeping the message but not the form; also called loose translation. (Chapter 10)

Functional equivalence التكافؤ الوظيفي Using a target-language expression that serves the same function, whatever its form. (Chapter 9)

Functional translation الترجمة الوظيفية Translating with a target-language expression that has the same function. (Chapter 13)

Genre الجنس النصي The type of text, such as a news report, a contract or a poem. (Chapter 17)

Hallucination الهلوسة Information produced by an AI tool that is not in the source text. (Chapter 22)

Homonymy المشترك اللفظي One word with several meanings that are not related. (Chapter 6)

Ideational equivalence التكافؤ الفكري Giving only the basic idea, in plain words. (Chapter 9)

Ideology الأيديولوجيا A set of beliefs that shapes how people describe events. (Chapter 19)

Idiom التعبير الاصطلاحي A fixed expression of more than one word whose meaning is not the sum of the meanings of its words. (Chapter 8)

Interpreting الترجمة الشفهية Transferring spoken language into another language. (Chapter 1)

Justification التبرير The reason why a translation choice is right. (Chapter 25)

Lexical creation النحت المعجمي The deliberate coinage of new words or expressions in the target language for items that have no direct equivalent. (Chapter 16)

Literal translation الترجمة الحرفية Keeping the words of the original and changing only what the grammar requires. Also called modified literal translation (الترجمة الحرفية المعدلة). (Chapter 10)

Loaded word كلمة مشحونة A word that carries a judgement, positive or negative. (Chapter 19)

Loan translation (calque) الترجمة المستعارة Translating the parts of a compound word one by one. (Chapter 16)

Machine translation (MT) الترجمة الآلية Translation done by software, such as online translation tools or AI chat tools. (Chapter 22)

Macro context السياق الخارجي The wider situation: the author, audience, time, place and circumstances of a text. (Chapter 6)

Meaning المعنى The idea that a form expresses. (Chapter 4)

Mental draft المسودة الذهنية A first idea of the translation that you form while reading the text. (Chapter 2)

Metaphor الاستعارة A comparison without “as” or “like”; using a word in a non-basic meaning. (Chapter 11)

Micro context (co-text) السياق الداخلي The words and sentences immediately around a word. (Chapter 6)

Modern Standard Arabic (MSA) الفصحى المعاصرة The Arabic of newspapers, laws and education. (Chapter 3)

Modulation التحوير Expressing the same idea from another point of view. (Chapter 12)

Monolingual dictionary معجم أحادي اللغة A dictionary that explains words in the same language. (Chapter 20)

Neologism اللفظ المستحدث A completely new word. (Chapter 16)

Omission الحذف Leaving out words that are unnecessary in the target language. (Chapter 13)

Polysemy تعدّد المعنى One word with several meanings that are related. (Chapter 6)

Post-editing التحرير اللاحق A human correcting and improving machine translation. (Chapter 22)

Proverb المثل A traditional saying that gives advice or states a truth. (Chapter 8)

Register المستوى اللغوي How formal or informal the language is. (Chapter 3)

Revision المراجعة Checking a translation against the source and correcting it. (Chapter 23)

Risk الخطر The chance that a translation choice causes a problem, and how serious that problem would be. (Chapter 24)

Risk management إدارة المخاطر Spending more effort where a mistake could cause more harm. (Chapter 24)

Risk matrix مصفوفة تقييم المخاطر A table that lists possible risks, how serious they are, and what to do about them. (Chapter 24)

Self-initiated translator مترجم بمبادرة ذاتية A translator who chooses a text to translate, with no client. (Chapter 1)

Sentence meaning معنى الجملة What the words of a sentence say. (Chapter 5)

Simile التشبيه A comparison that uses “as” or “like”. (Chapter 11)

Skopos theory نظرية الغاية The idea that the purpose of a translation decides how it is translated. (Chapter 26)

Source text (ST) النص المصدر The original text that you translate. (Chapter 1)

Speaker meaning مقصد المتكلم What the speaker really means by saying it. (Chapter 5)

Specialised dictionary معجم متخصص A dictionary for one field, such as law or medicine. (Chapter 20)

Subtitling الترجمة المرئية / السترجة Showing a written translation of the dialogue at the bottom of the screen. (Chapter 27)

- Taboo language** اللغة المحظورة Words that a society or religion forbids or restricts, such as swear words. (Chapter 27)
- Target audience** الجمهور المستهدف The people who will read the translation. (Chapter 2)
- Target text (TT)** النص الهدف Your translation. (Chapter 1)
- Term** المصطلح A word or expression that names a concept in a special field. (Chapter 21)
- Term list** قائمة المصطلحات A list of the approved terms for a project, with their translations. (Chapter 21)
- Termbase** قاعدة بيانات المصطلحات A database of terms and information about them. (Chapter 21)
- Terminologist** المصطلحي A specialist who creates and standardises terms, usually in one language. (Chapter 21)
- Terminology** علم المصطلح The study, collection and management of specialised terms. (Chapter 21)
- Terminology guide** دليل المصطلحات A document that tells translators which terms to use for a client. (Chapter 21)
- Text** النص Anything written: a word, a sentence, a paragraph or more. (Chapter 17)
- Text analysis** تحليل النص Breaking down and studying a text before translating it. (Chapter 17)
- Text type** نوع النص A group of texts with the same main function: to inform, to express or to persuade. (Chapter 18)
- Tone** النبرة The writer's attitude: neutral, critical, friendly, straightforward. (Chapter 17)
- Translation** الترجمة التحريرية Transferring the meaning of a written text from one language into another. (Chapter 1)
- Translation brief** موجز الترجمة The information you need before you start: client, purpose and audience. (Chapter 2)
- Translation commentary** التعليق على الترجمة A text that explains the problems in a translation and justifies the solutions. (Chapter 25)
- Translation procedure** إجراء الترجمة A technique for translating a word, phrase or sentence. (Chapter 12)
- Translation strategy** استراتيجية الترجمة A planned solution to a translation problem. (Chapter 13)
- Transliteration** النقل الصوتي Writing the sounds of a word in the letters of another language. (Chapter 15)
- Transposition** الإبدال Changing the word class, for example a noun into a verb. (Chapter 12)
- Verbal sentence** الجملة الفعلية A sentence that starts with a verb. (Chapter 3)

Voice-over التعليق الصوتي Recording a translation over the original voice, which can still be heard quietly. (Chapter 26)

Word order ترتيب الكلمات The order of the subject, verb and object in a sentence. (Chapter 3)

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“Translate the meaning, not the words.”

ترجم المعنى، لا الكلمات.

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WHO IT IS FOR

Students and beginners taking their first steps in translation, and participants in the Guild Season workshops.